Introduction |

Why India Matters, Why the World Matters

In 2008, the Tata Group, which originated as a trading company in nineteenth-century Bombay, purchased Jaguar Land Rover, and assumed ownership of a pair of venerated British brands famous for luxury sports cars and off-road vehicles. Seven years later, in 2015, the US Embassy in Yemen, concerned about the deteriorating security situation in that country, advised American citizens to seek assistance from the Indian government. Over ten days, using resources available to its military, India evacuated citizens of more than thirty countries from a contested war zone. Eight years after that, in 2023, a three-metre-long spacecraft designed in Gujarat, developed in Karnataka, and launched from Andhra Pradesh became the first man-made object to make a successful soft landing near the moon's southern pole.

These three separate events—demonstrations of India's growing international role in the corporate, military, and technological realms—generated considerable pride in India and a degree of surprise elsewhere. Taken together, they signified India's growing role in international affairs. But what is appreciated less often is that India has a rich legacy of international exchange and influence, one that has altered both India and the world in some unexpected ways.

As India rises, it is increasingly clear that the world matters for its future. It has one of the world's largest diasporas, the second-largest number of overseas students, and is among the largest recipients of remittances. It is a major trader and market, with among the largest current account deficits of any economy. It is the world's third-largest energy importer and, in recent years, has been among the world's largest arms buyers and recipients of greenfield foreign direct investment, signalling new corporate operations in the country.[1] Whether for its territorial defence or overall economy, its knowledge or power, its food or human security, India's future will be